

Parivartan Sthal. "The aesthetics and beauty have been replaced with cheap pomp and panoply", observed a senior engineer who has worked on the project through the overhaul. On the direction of the new architect and contractors, a marble statue of Lord Buddha has been removed from the Sthal and two spots earmarked for statues of the late Kanshi Ram and Mayawati. The sandstone for the project is being excavated from a quarry in Mirzapur. It is first transported to Bayana near Jaipur to be cut and polished, and then brought to Lucknow in hordes of trucks. The project, however, is surrounded by a veil of secrecy with officials from the Public

been constituted for the celebrations under the chairmanship of PWD minister and trusted lieutenant, Naseemuddin Siddiqui. At a "*Saavdhan Raho, Aage Badho* (be cautious, march ahead)" rally in Lucknow on October 9—also Kanshi Ram's first death anniversary—the chief minister announced 13 new projects worth more than Rs 9,500 crore to be named after the late BSP ideologue and announced that his birth anniversary, March 15, would be a holiday.

A project in the memory of Rama Bai Ambedkar, wife of Bhimrao Ambedkar, is also in the pipeline and work is on in full swing to spruce up the site. Apart from a life-size statue of

religious sites like Ayodhya have given way to those of Dalit leaders such as Phule, Periyar and Mayawati in the calendar. In the mid-'90s, when she had become chief minister for the first time, Mayawati had tried to put up in Lucknow a statue of Periyar—an iconoclast who had burnt the Ramayan in his time—but had to refrain because of strong protests. This time, with BSP holding an absolute majority in the state, the statues of Periyar are being installed with hardly a murmur of protest being heard.

However, this Dalitisation of the state is at odds with a supposed Brahminisation of the party. The BSP had come into power with Brahmin

HECTIC: Labourers working at the Kanshi Ram Memorial site



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Works Department (PWD) and the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) refusing to comment.

This is not the only place on the banks of the river Gomati, where the state machinery is busy Dalitising the landscape on the orders of the chief minister. The multi-crore Kanshi Ram Memorial is another of her pet projects, which will come up at the huge Ambedkar Ground where political rallies and a fortnight-long Lucknow festival are held. The blueprint is yet to be finalised, but it will be a museum where the life and achievements of Kanshi Ram will be depicted. The Government has already announced week-long celebrations from March 11 to 17 to mark the birth anniversary of Mayawati's mentor and a series of cultural programmes have been finalised. A special committee has

Rama Bai, the memorial will also have photographs celebrating her life and times. The right bank of the Sharda canal is being beautified for the erection of 11 statues of Dalit icons like Ambedkar, Kanshi Ram, Jyotiba Rao Phule, Chatrapati Shauji Maharaj, Ramaswami Naicker Periyar and the chief minister herself. The Cabinet has also decided to build another Kanshi Ram memorial at 13, Mall Avenue, a bungalow now allotted to Mayawati where her mentor had stayed for long. Adjoining bungalows are also to be included in this memorial, but a petition has been filed in the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court to stop the demolition. The Government, though, is going ahead with its plan.

Not wanting to be left behind in the celebration of Dalit icons, the Cultural Department has joined in with its annual calendar of events. Pictures of

support, and some, such as the Cabinet minister Satish Chand Mishra have become a parallel power centre, pushing kith and kin into key positions. This has created discontent among the cadres and Mayawati is working hard to convince her workers that Dalits aren't being marginalised. At the October 9 rally, the usual aggression of her speech was replaced by defensiveness. Also, there is pressure on the chief minister from several quarters with thousands of police constables and teachers losing their jobs, sugarcane farmers not getting their dues from the mills, a students' union being banned and allegations of BSP funds being misused by her brother.

"*Sarvajan hitaya, sarvajan sukhai* (welfare and prosperity of all sections of society)" might be Mayawati's doctrine, but her actions are a far cry from such lofty ideals. ■

CM'S PET PROJECTS

■ Ambedkar Sthal, worth Rs 447 crore, will have statues of Kanshi Ram and Mayawati along with a canal and high-rising domes.

■ The Kanshi Ram Memorial will be a museum where the works and achievements of the late BSP leader will be depicted.

■ The Rs 60-crore Rama Bai Ambedkar Maidan will celebrate the life and times of Ambedkar's wife and will also have her life-size statue.